

Harnessing India's population potential

On World Population Day, India stands **at a crossroads** and must balance its population growth

We humans are now eight billion and counting. That's correct — the world population is on an upward **trajectory**, and at the growing rate, it would **surpass** 10 billion well before **the turn of this century**. This could be a difficult situation as it puts **enormous** pressure on the Earth's limited resources. However, **many other issues**, such as the environment, **take precedence**, and the population does not get the attention it deserves. But the population **bomb is ticking**, and the sooner it is realised, the better. Every year on July 11, World Population Day serves as a global reminder of the **pressing** issues related to population — ranging from overpopulation and reproductive health to gender equality and **sustainable** development. Initiated by the United Nations in 1989, World Population Day is a **stark** reminder of the critical **interplay** between population and the social and economic **order** and its impact on the environment.

Some countries are already facing the **strain** of rapid population growth, while others are **contending** with **ageing** populations and **shrinking** workforces. Among them, India occupies a unique and complex position. India's population has surpassed 1.4 billion. This **immense demographic** presence is both a potential strength and a **looming** challenge. On one hand, **a large young population** — over 50 per cent under the age of 30 — **offers** a huge workforce. On the other hand, the country must **address** employment gaps and reproductive health inequities. Though in recent **decades** there has been a steep decline in India's fertility rates, the situation is still unmanageable. The national **Total Fertility Rate** has fallen from more than five children per woman in the 1970s to around 2.0 as of the latest National Family Health Survey. This figure is now close to the replacement-level fertility of 2.1, which is required to maintain a **stable** population in the long term.

However, there are **sharp** regional **differences**. **Southern states** such as Kerala, Tamil Nadu, and Andhra Pradesh **have** already gone well below the replacement rate, while **northern and central states** like Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, and Madhya Pradesh **continue** to record higher fertility rates, **reflecting** deeper issues of **poverty, illiteracy**, and limited access to healthcare. Another concern **lies** in the gap between the Total Fertility Rate and the Total Wanted Fertility Rate (TWFR), which reflects the number of children women desire to have. This indicates a significant **incidence** of unintended pregnancies and **highlights persistent shortcomings** in access to family planning, contraceptive choices, and reproductive rights. India's challenge also lies in ensuring that its growing population finds productive engagement. The country adds over 10 million people to the working-age population each year. However, job creation has not **kept pace** with this **surge, resulting in** growing unemployment. The **demographic dividend** becomes a **liability** if skill development and employment generation are not adequately prioritised. **Education**, particularly of girls, **is perhaps** the most transformative tool in managing population growth. World Population Day serves as a reminder that managing population is not just about controlling numbers — it's about enabling choices, protecting

rights, and ensuring that **every individual**, especially women and girls, **has** access to the resources and opportunities they need to **thrive**.

[Practice exercise]

- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

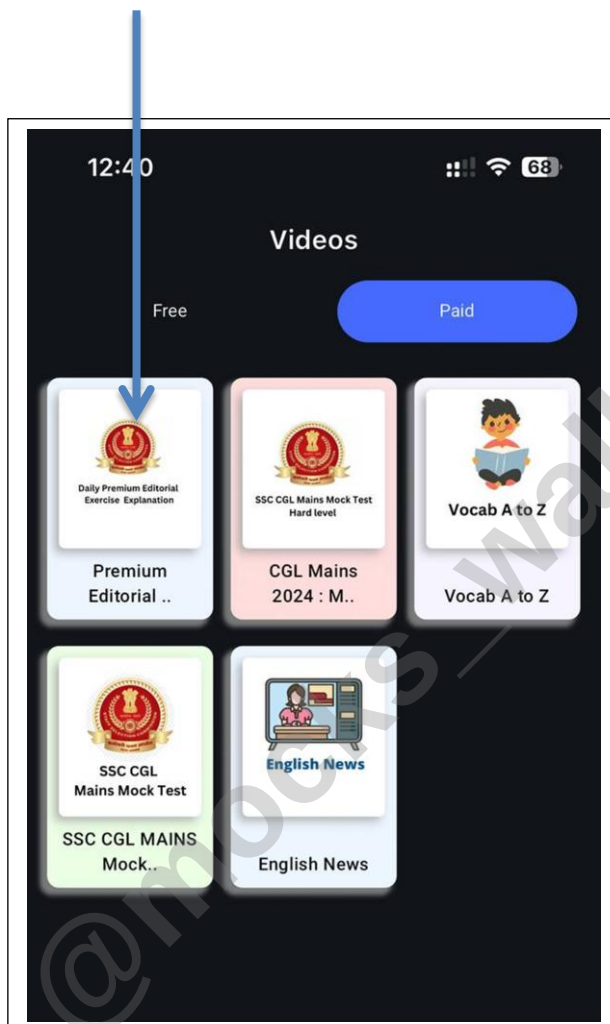
@mocks_wallah

Vocabulary

1. **Harness** (verb) – utilize, control, exploit, channel, make use of उपयोग करना
2. **Potential** (noun) – capability, capacity, promise, possibility, ability क्षमता
3. **At a crossroad** (phrase) – at a critical point, at a turning point, in a dilemma, at a decisive moment, facing choices एक निर्णायक मोड़ पर
4. **Trajectory** (noun) – path, course, direction, route, movement प्रक्षेपवक्र / विकास मार्ग
5. **Surpass** (verb) – exceed, outdo, overtake, transcend, beat पार कर जाना / अधिक होना
6. **The turn of this century** (phrase) – the time when a particular century ends and another begins
7. **Enormous** (adjective) – huge, massive, immense, gigantic, tremendous विशाल
8. **Take precedence** (phrase) – be more important, be prioritized, take priority, come first, outweigh अधिक महत्व देना
9. **Bomb is ticking** (phrase) – danger is approaching, time is running out, crisis is nearing, threat is imminent खतरा धीरे-धीरे बढ़ रहा है
10. **Pressing** (adjective) – urgent, important, critical, crucial, immediate अत्यावश्यक
11. **Sustainable** (adjective) – viable, long-lasting, eco-friendly, maintainable, renewable टिकाऊ
12. **Stark** (adjective) – clear, harsh, sharp, plain, extreme स्पष्ट
13. **Interplay** (noun) – interaction, connection, relationship, correlation, influence पारस्परिक प्रभाव
14. **Order** (noun) – system, structure, arrangement, framework, setup व्यवस्था
15. **Strain** (noun) – pressure, stress, burden, tension, demand दबाव
16. **Contend** (verb) – struggle, cope, face, fight, deal सामना करना
17. **Ageing** (adjective) – growing old, elderly, maturing, greying उम्रदराज़ होता हुआ
18. **Shrinking** (adjective) – reducing, declining, contracting, lessening, decreasing घटता हुआ
19. **Immense** (adjective) – vast, enormous, tremendous, huge, massive अपार / विशाल
20. **Demographic** (adjective) – population-related, statistical, societal जनसंख्या-संबंधी
21. **Looming** (adjective) – approaching, impending, threatening, emerging, upcoming आसन्न

22. **Address** (verb) – tackle, deal with, handle, attend to, resolve समाधान करना
23. **Decade** (noun) – Period of ten years दशक
24. **Total Fertility Rate** (noun) – It represents the average number of children a woman is expected to have in her lifetime, based on current birth rates प्रजनन दर
25. **Stable** (adjective) – steady, consistent, balanced, unchanging, firm स्थिर
26. **Sharp** (adjective) – distinct, clear, noticeable, significant, steep तीव्र / स्पष्ट
27. **Differences** (noun) – variations, contrasts, disparities, distinctions, divergences अंतर
28. **Reflect** (verb) – indicate, show, reveal, demonstrate, express प्रतिबिंबित करना
29. **Poverty** (noun) – deprivation, destitution, lack, hardship, need गरीबी
30. **Illiteracy** (noun) – lack of education, ignorance, unawareness, unreadability अशिक्षा
31. **Lie** (verb) – reside, exist, be situated, be present स्थित होना
32. **Incidence** (noun) – occurrence, rate, frequency, prevalence, number घटना की दर
33. **Highlight** (verb) – emphasize, underline, stress, point out, showcase उजागर करना
34. **Persistent** (adjective) – continuous, constant, unrelenting, ongoing, enduring लगातार
35. **Shortcoming** (noun) – deficiency, flaw, limitation, drawback, imperfection कमी
36. **Keep pace** (phrase) – stay up, keep up, match speed, remain aligned साथ चलना
37. **Surge** (noun) – rise, increase, upsurge, spike, boost वृद्धि
38. **Result in** (phrasal verb) – lead to, cause, bring about, produce, culminate in परिणामस्वरूप होना
39. **Demographic dividend** (noun) – economic benefit from a young population, youth advantage जनसांख्यिकीय लाभान्श
40. **Liability** (noun) – burden, drawback, disadvantage, hindrance, obligation बोझ / दायित्व
41. **Perhaps** (adverb) – maybe, possibly, conceivably, probably, likely शायद
42. **Thrive** (verb) – flourish, prosper, grow, succeed, bloom फलना-फूलना

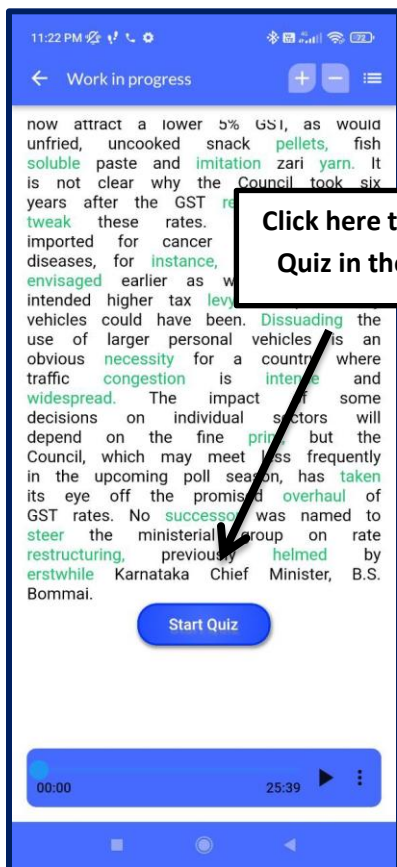
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



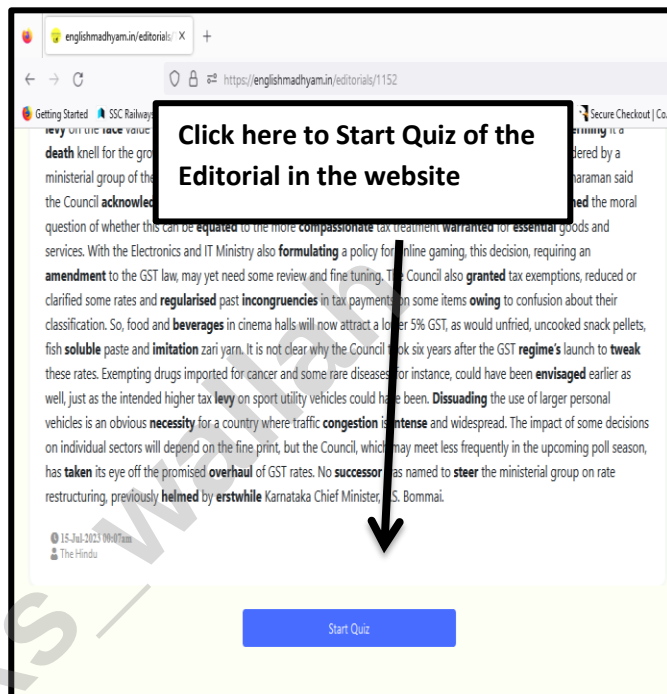
Summary of the Editorial

1. World Population Day Reminder: Observed on July 11, it highlights critical issues such as overpopulation, reproductive health, gender equality, and sustainable development.
2. Global Context: The world population is over 8 billion and projected to exceed 10 billion by the end of this century, putting pressure on limited resources.
3. Neglected Crisis: While environmental concerns dominate global discussions, population growth remains under-discussed, despite being a major underlying issue.
4. India's Unique Position: India, with over 1.4 billion people, holds a complex demographic position — both a potential advantage and a looming concern.
5. Youthful Demographic: Over 50% of Indians are under 30, offering a huge workforce, potentially aiding economic growth if properly harnessed.
6. Fertility Rate Decline: India's Total Fertility Rate (TFR) has dropped from 5+ in the 1970s to around 2.0, nearing the replacement level of 2.1.
7. Regional Disparities: Southern states (e.g., Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh) are below replacement level, while northern states (e.g., UP, Bihar) still have high fertility rates.
8. Socioeconomic Link: High fertility in northern India is tied to poverty, low literacy, and inadequate healthcare access.
9. Unintended Pregnancies: The gap between TFR and Total Wanted Fertility Rate (TWFR) points to unmet needs for family planning and poor reproductive health services.
10. Job Creation Lag: India adds 10 million working-age people every year, but employment opportunities are not keeping pace, leading to rising joblessness.
11. Demographic Dividend at Risk: Without investment in skill development and job creation, the youth bulge could become a burden rather than a benefit.
12. Reproductive Rights: Many women still lack access to contraception and family planning, reflecting inequities in reproductive choices.
13. Education is Key: Especially girls' education is critical to slowing population growth and improving socioeconomic outcomes.
14. Balanced Approach Needed: Managing population is not just controlling numbers, but enabling informed choices and protecting individual rights.
15. Policy Imperative: India must act strategically — balancing development with population concerns — to turn a demographic challenge into an opportunity.

Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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